In turn, the generals set up the National Unity Party (NUP) as a political front to legitimise their continuing rule. The poll proved to be a debacle for the ruling party. Aung San Suu Kyi's opposition NLD won over 80 per cent of the seats.

3. 1990 Electoral Results[48]

Party	*Seats Won (total 485)*	*% of Seats Won*
National League for Democracy (NLD)	392	80.8
Shan Nationalities League for Democracy (SNLD)	23	4.7
Arakan League for Democracy (ALD)	11	2.3
National Unity Party (NUP)	10	2.1
Other Parties (23) and independents	49	10.1

In total, twenty-seven parties won seats, the majority of these being smaller ethnicity-based parties winning seats in their own provinces. In particular, the ALD won eleven out of twenty-seven seats in Rakhine. Rather than acquiesce to electoral defeat, the military annulled the elections on 27 July 1990, announcing that the ruling junta would remain in power until a new constitution was created. Most of the parties that had contested the election were banned, but the NLD was allowed to function legally, in principle, while their power was curtailed by harassing and often simply arresting their representatives.

The NLD, in response, created the Committee Representing the People's Parliament (CRPP) to act in place of the banned assembly and elected the leader of the ALD to be its first speaker.[49] In effect, one of the first voluntary acts by the NLD was to closely ally itself with a Buddhist confessional party that was already calling for the expulsion of the Rohingyas, its leader stressing 'a Rakhine claim to the west bank of the Nat River, which Rakhines had "inherited from their ancestors" but been forced to evacuate during the wars'.[50]

A Rohingya activist who had stood for election told the author that there was a particularly anti-Rohingya aspect to the crackdown and one that indicated a worrying trend of collusion between the NLD and the military in this respect. One charge that was used to justify stripping parliamentarians of their seats was that of using fake identity cards. Conviction led to sentences of up to forty years in prison.[51] This form of repression was specifically aimed at those from the Rohingya community